Catra: Wedding Planner

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25718821.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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Catra: Wedding Planner

by OrangeKryptonite

Summary

As the Best Friends Squad leaves on an important diplomatic mission, Catra is left behind to work out plans for the up coming wedding. Glimmer and Catra have an argument.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

“Catra: Wedding Planner”

“Everyone has a place in my empire, you will be use to me yet.”

Horde Prime’s words buzzed in Catra’s ears, filling her head with a metallic resonance. She squeezed her eyes tightly shut trying to force out the voice.

With a slight start Catra opened her eyes. She sat up, her breath was shallow and her heart beat felt like a rapid flutter. She rubbed her eyes and shook her head gently, trying to shake off the dream. Her and Adora’s room in Bright Moon castle was lit by silver moonlight. The balcony in their room over looked the runestone and it’s pulsing energy made the light in their room seem to shimmer.

She felt Adora stir slightly. Adora was asleep, mouth open, breathing slowly, hair covering half her face. Catra gently brushed Adora’s hair aside and filled with a sense of pride. The next week was going to be big for Adora and she did not want to wake her.

Melog started to purr softly at the foot of the bed. Catra slipped out of the covers and curled up against Melog, pressing her face into her cat’s soft fur. Melog breathed deeply, stretched and settled against Catra as they both drifted back to sleep.

***

Adora opened her eyes. She had been having trouble staying asleep. The anticipation of her mission weighted heavily on her mind. In the morning she would be leaving with Bow and Glimmer for a week long diplomatic trip. Even though Glimmer and Bow would be doing most of the actual negotiating, Adora was still nervous. She’d never had to be a…. what did Bow call it? A “figurehead” before. Also it meant a week without Catra.

Adora turned and reached out to pull Catra closer. Her hand fell on an empty bed. Propping herself up slightly, she looked to the foot of the bed and saw Catra was cuddling Melog.

“Catra.” Adora whispered, “Catra, are you awake?”

Catra didn’t move. Adora looked at them curled up together and a slight twinge of jealousy poked her. Slipping from under the covers Adora did her best to sneak behind Catra, laying out behind her. She put her hand over Catra’s where it rested on Melog’s side and nestled against her. She felt Catra tense up and Adora’s breath cut short, worried she’d done something wrong. Adora’s tension abated as Catra relaxed against her. Adora grinned slightly and drifted back to sleep.

***

Glimmer sat in front of her vanity mirror, slowly brushing her hair. She had woken up early to get properly prepared for formal brunch. It was a frequent responsibility of hers, as Queen, to entertain dignitaries from distant parts of Etheria. Other princesses and princes would throw elaborate dinner balls with eight course meals, servants, decorations, music. Elaborate, formal. Glimmer preferred to keep things less formal. She felt less formal did not equate to less important for her. Guests could still mingle, there would still be time for speeches and discussion of political and courtly intrigue just without the ridged adherence to pomp and circumstance.

She slipped on her tunic, loose fitting, knee length with a dove tail hem. It was made of fine amethyst sateen fabric embroidered with silver thread. Glimmer, even as queen, felt it was important for her apparel to express her personality. Bold. Dynamic. Sparkly. She shook out her hair and teased in a deeper part. Glimmer stood up and gave herself one last look over in the mirror. She gave herself a slight nod of approval before turning to leave.

Her room was on the far side of the castle from the great hall where meals were held. She took a deep breath and exhaled

slowly before stepping out into the hallway. As Queen she needed to be seen. If she just teleported to the great hall she felt her subjects would see her as avoiding contact with them.

She could do this. She had grown up in this castle, crawled through every corridor, peeked in every room, hidden in every closet and cupboard. She knew the way like the back of her hand, but now a simple walk to the great hall took every ounce of her concentration. It was better when she was with Bow or Adora, someone to distract her, but she knew if she focused on the brightly lit corridors she felt like they stretched on forever. Her heart would start to race and fear that she could lose her way in her own castle could strike at any moment.

Glimmer put her head down and walked through the halls with determination for her destination. Instinct and memory would guide her. Her pace quickened and her breathing became rapid. Glimmer barely registered the guard's pushing open the door to the great hall and announcing her entrance.

"Queen Glimmer." The guard's announcement was loud and clear, snapping Glimmer's attention to the room she entered.

Glimmer stopped at the entrance of the great hall and looked over the room. The assembled dignitaries had stood for her entrance, Bow and Adora were standing at the head of the table smiling across it to her, Catra's chair was, of course, empty. Glimmer breathed a sigh of relief and gave a curtsy before taking her seat between Bow and Adora. As soon as she was seated the room retook theirs and the sounds of conversation began anew.

"You look absolutely radiant this morning, darling. What's the occasion?" Bow's tone was playful and he leaned lightly on his elbow as he turned to give Glimmer a broad smile.

"Um…" Glimmer waved her hand broadly, as if to indicate the entirety of the room. The assemble dignitaries, mostly diplomats, were from the Princess Alliance and here to discuss the beginning of a series of diplomatic missions to planets across their corner of

the galaxy. “The big diplomatic thing we’re going to do. In space!?” As soon as she finished her sentence she heard Entrapta’s voice from across the room excitedly proclaim “SPACE!”

Adora snorted a laugh. Glimmer and Bow shared a quick kiss and Glimmer playfully shook her head.

“You two… Hey, where’s Catra?” Glimmer nodded to the chair next to Adora.

“Oh, I figured I would give her the chance to sleep in a little. She was having a hard time sleeping last night.” Adora was feigning as much nonchalance as she could muster as she went about cutting up her pancakes.

“You seem to let her sleep in a lot.” Glimmer’s tone was probing.

Adora pushed a large piece of her pancake into her mouth, staring straight ahead. “She has a hard time sleeping a lot.” The sound of her voice was made squishy and muddled by the food in her mouth.

“Adora, if you want we can take her with us, she doesn’t need to stay here just to do paperwork.” Glimmer put her hand on Adora’s arm and tried to sound reassuring. The four of them had been through a lot together and Glimmer could see the concern on Adora’s face even as she tried to hide it behind pancakes.

“Catra App…” The announcement of Catra’s entrance was cut short. The assembled room’s eyes turned and saw Catra glaring daggers at the guard. Catra rolled her eyes and walked to the head of the table once she was confident the guard wouldn’t finish the announcement.

Glimmer’s eyes followed Catra as she walked with a playful sway to sit next to Adora. As she neared, Catra’s eyes met Glimmer’s and quickly broke off.

“What’s up, nerds.” Catra’s greeting was delivered with her customary sarcasm as she plopped down into her chair.

At least she made it today, Glimmer's thought betrayed her mild frustration. Catra's habit of skipping meals worried Glimmer but she couldn't help feeling Catra's dismissive attitude toward meetings of state affairs was disrespectful. Glimmer remembered the princesses gathering to allocate relief for the Fright Zone and Salineas. Seeing Catra sit silently next to Adora, leaning on her elbow, staring at the cover page of Bow's report didn't sit well with her. Even when the discussion turned to organizing the recovery of the Fright Zone, Catra, who knew the Fright Zone and the Horde than most, added nothing.

Glimmer also remembered having to talk down Mermista after the meeting. She had no kind words for "the supposedly reformed mastermind of destroying my home." Glimmer could only offer her halfhearted apologetics and a promise to talk to Catra. A conversation that would be walking an emotional tightrope between Adora and Catra. A conversation Glimmer desperately wanted to avoid with Catra being so avoidant and aloof.

Catra's entrance had held Glimmer's attention and she barely caught a silver glint out of the corner of her eye. A silver platter had been placed in front of her and a hand slowly raised the lid. Glimmer's hand clenched the white table cloth in front of her, her jaw tightened.

"Oatmeal and with sliced citrus fruits, your highness." The cook bowed slightly.

"Th… thank you." Glimmer looked down at her breakfast and then quickly glanced up at Adora and Catra. They were gazing into each other's eyes and probably wouldn't even notice if an elemental came crashing through the windows. Glimmer let out a small breath of relief.

"Glimmer, are you okay …" Bow had leaned in and whispered into Glimmer's ear. She jumped slightly and gave a sharp gasp. He continued, "I know Catra can be pretty abrasive…" Glimmer looked over to Bow, his brow was furrowed with concern.

“No, I’m fine.” Glimmer cut Bow off. “It’s okay.” She gave Bow a quick smile and began eating her breakfast. Bow gave a shrug and went back to eating his.

As she ate Glimmer tried to slow her breathing and steady her nerves. There was a lump in her throat that made swallowing was uncomfortable and her body wanted to reject any trespass of nourishment.

This was going to be a long week.

***

The makeshift hangar set up outside Bright Moon castle was filled with of activity. Entrapta, riding around on her robot friend Emily, was busily performing pre-flight checks on their First Ones spaceship, Darla. Her voice carried across the landing pad, hurried, concerned, but with twice her usual excitement. Mara’s ship had been through so much and, while work continued on developing a second ship, Darla was still their only way off Etheria.

Catra had other concerns.

“Are you sure you want me to take her with us?”

Adora’s voice was a mixture of incredulity and concern. Melog was more than just Catra’s pet, they were empathically bonded.

“You said it yourself that you were going to give a presentation of Etherian magic. What better display of magic than a shape-shifting cat that can turn invisible!” Catra’s voice raised toward the end of her sentence as she gestured, arms stretched out toward Melog. Melog mewled in agreement.

“But, uh… Catra, Melog isn’t from Etheria?”

“Duh, dork, they don’t know that! Besides, Adora, I would feel a lot more comfortable if you took her with you. You know, in case you run into trouble … or something.”

“Catra, you know I’m the muscle on this mission, right?” Adora’s voice took on a slightly smug tone. “Besides, as figurehead in charge of … uh … She-Ra, I plan on dazzling them with an epic laser light show accompanied by some even more epic poses.”

Adora started going through the flexing routine she had worked out, with Catra’s help of course, to show off She-Ra’s awesome might. Catra pressed her palm to her forehead and blushed slightly.

“Yeah, maybe you should save She-Ra for, like, a finale or something?”

Adora grinned. “That is a great idea, Catra. You always have such a great sense for theatrics!”

Catra laughed. “Yeah, I guess I do have that.” Catra looked over toward Glimmer who was at a table finalizing plans with the Etherian delegates. Catra’s expression became earnest.

“Adora, don’t worry. I’ll be okay in Bright Moon. Besides! I have too much planning to do for the wedding!”

No sooner than she finished her thought than a piece of paper slid down in front of her eyes. Catra took the paper and Entrapta’s hair silently lifted out of her view. Catra looked over her shoulder to see an intensely grinning Entrapta staring at Catra as Emily carried her up the ramp to board Darla. “What is it?” Adora’s face and voice betrayed a level of serious concern.

Catra scanned the piece of paper and let out a strained sigh. “This, Adora, appears to be a technical treatise on the logistical superiority of catering weddings with …” Catra let out an even more strained sigh that would have made Mermista proud. “… tiny foods.”

A moment passed where Adora and Catra looked at each other, in complete seriousness until they could no longer hold it together. They burst out laughing, leaning into each other.

"We have the weirdest friends."

Adora nodded in agreement, wiping a tear from the corner of her eye.

"Hey, look, it's just a week. We'll be back before you know it." Adora took Catra's hands in hers, looking into her eyes as she leaned in, kissing her softly.

Catra's mind lingered on Adora's touch for a moment before she gently pushed her back.

"Hey, you're just going to be jealous of all the fun I'm going to have now that I don't have you nerds holding me back."

Adora slowly pulled away letting her hand tug at Catra's arm, sliding down until their contact broke at their finger tips. Adora followed Glimmer and Bow up the ramp to board Darla and the three of them, the Best Friends Squad (minus Catra), waved good-byes to Catra. The ramp slowly closed as Catra backed away and held a hand up to shield her eyes from the dust blowing off the landing pad as Darla slowly lifted off. She stayed, watching as Darla slowly shrink until she couldn't see the ship against the Etherian sky. Softly stroking her pony tail, Catra walked back to the castle alone.

***

Catra stretched as she walked through the halls of Bright Moon castle. Under her arm was what Catra could only assume was a massive bundle of replies to the wedding invitations they had sent out. This was the consequence of having a dual ceremony with

Bow and Glimmer and while most of their friends overlapped Glimmer was queen and as such had many political obligations. Not to mention the invites sent out to the Horde clones.

At that thought Catra smirked a little. Horde clones. It was expected that Bright Moon's subjects would attend the wedding and many of the clones had chosen to settle here. They had also scattered across Etheria to assert new found self determination and autonomy. Catra remembered the meeting where Glimmer proposed sending invitations out to the clone enclaves across the many kingdoms. She said it was an important gesture of peace and reconciliation. Catra was almost certain it was Bow's idea; but, Adora agreed and Catra felt she didn't have any real objection to the idea so the deed was done. Horde clones galore would pack the ceremony hall and courtyard with all their wild expressions of individuality.

Catra stopped in the middle of the hall and rolled her eyes. She let out a little sigh and looked at the room she was standing outside. A mischievous grin crept across her face. She looked up and down the hall to make sure no one would see her enter.

"Hello, Glimmer's office. Don't mind me while I make myself at home!" Catra dropped the stack of replies on the desk and dropped hard into the thickly cushioned chair. It rolled back slightly and started to spin. Catra felt as if she would be absorbed into the softness.

"Arg! Why is everything in Bright Moon so SQUISHY!" Catra growled as she extracted herself from the cushion. Years of living in the Fright Zone had trained her to appreciate a certain spartan aesthetic. Dinner sitting on flat benches. Class sitting on metal chairs. Sleeping on thin mattresses. Catra was glad that Adora still hadn't lost the appreciation for a good firm mattress. The only thing that Bright Moon had over the Fright Zone on comfort was the clothing. They somehow managed to get both sharply cut uniforms and loose gossamer gowns to fit well and move with the body unrestricted. Not to mention Catra was never upset to see Adora wearing the looser styles common in the castle. Catra gave

a little contented sigh and pushed back a little letting the chair roll on the carpeted floor.

Her mischievous grin widened.

***

Standing in front of the throne room, two Bight Moon guards kept silent vigil. Renowned for their stoic nature the guards of the castle could stand on duty for an entire day without a break. Even during battle with the Horde the guards rarely suffered casualties as their prowess in combat was unparalleled! They also made a fine cup of coffee. Yes, these guards were the envy of all the other princess and princesses.

A sound was approaching from further down the corridor. A sound of wheels rolling on stone, of bearings whining in protest of speed and danger! And with it another sound. A squeal of delight and freedom!

Catra was riding Glimmer's chair down the hall, slowing to a stop and finishing with a spin as it came to rest in front of the two guards. They both looked down at her, stoic. Unmoved.

"What are you looking at, ya' squares!" Catra blurted out as she got off the chair and pushed it back to her new office.

Catra sat down to finally start going through the invitation replies. Grabbing the first one off the stack she read the name on the front out loud, "Mermista."

"Oh, let me guess? Yes!" Catra opened the letter and read. "And her plus one is Seahawk. No duh."

Catra picked up the next invitation and opened it. Some random certainly important person from Thaymor was coming.

Surely a great achievement of political maneuvering, Sparkles. Catra thought.

She grabbed the next invitation off the pile. Nobody important couldn't make it. Next! Someone from wherever was so happy to come. Catra gave a little frustrated grunt. Was there anyone in this pile that she knew that wasn't also friends with Glimmer and Bow?!

Rifling through the pile of unopened letters Catra finally found one that piqued her interest.

"Rogelio." Catra smirked. Her former colleague was difficult to read so she had at least some mystery as to if he would say 'yes.'

Catra slowly opened the invitation, giggling in anticipation. As she read the letter her expression dropped. The letter read:

Dear Catra and Adora,

I hope my letter finds you in good health, but I regret to inform you that we will not be attending your wedding. Lonnie, Kyle and I had a discussion and, bless her, Lonnie would not budge. Kyle and I will be staying here to support Lonnie's decision. We hope some day that you will be able to visit, but for now that will not be possible. It will take some time, but; I am sure Lonnie will let go of some of her anger and we can all meet again.

Best Wishes,

Rogelio and Kyle.

PS.

Please keep this discrete, but Kyle and I are sending a gift along with Huntara.

"What is her PROBLEM!?" Catra slammed the letter down on the table knocking over Glimmer's tiny Bow figurine. Catra picked up her hands and the letter flitted off onto the floor.

"Arg."

Lonnie. I never liked you anyway… but…

Catra remembered how hopeful Adora was that they would see their old teammates at the wedding. A small knot settled in Catra's stomach as she reached down to pick up the letter. Under the desk she noticed a series of small, crude drawings in sparkly crayon. Catra's eyes focused on one in particular. A blue and purple winged stick figure with the word, "Momy" written under it.

Catra felt like the world suddenly dropped a foot beneath her. She triedto steady herself and get to her feet but hadn't pushed the chair back enough and hit her head on the bottom of the desk. The pain sharpened her senses and she crawled off the chair and back to her feet. The room felt suddenly alien, it's white walls and purple décor pressed down on Catra until she backed out the room.

Her heart was racing, her breath shallow, constricted. Catra knew this feeling, it was too familiar and brought her back to when she felt it on Horde Prime's ship. When the clones had grabbed her to… Catra shook her head violently.

Stop it. Stop thinking, Catra.

Catra ran her hand through her hair to the back of her neck and felt the hair tie that Adora had given her. Her hair had finally grown long enough that when she had it back in a pony tail it didn't look like a silly poof. Catra remembered when Adora gave her the hair tie she was so embarrassed that she had nothing to exchange. It was soon after their victory over Horde Prime and Catra had literally nothing but Adora, Melog, and the clothes on her back. Adora joked that they had exchanged hair styles.

Catra pulled the hair tie out of the short pony tail and wrapped it around her fingers. She held it under her nose and took a deep breath. She'd had it long enough it had lost Adora's scent. Catra looked around her, down at the castle's courtyard. She was sitting on the edge of the balcony outside her and Adora's room. The runestone pulsed with silent power in the distance.

I don't remember walking here… .

Catra's thought didn't matter, it was where she needed to be anyway. The last moon of the day was setting, her head was throbbing, and her bed was right there. Hopping off the edge of the balcony Catra slipped off her jacket and tossed it on her side of the bed. She would sleep on Adora's side of the bed tonight! Catra jumped on the bed and fell face first onto Adora's pillow. As she stretched out she took the hair tie off of her fingers and placed it on Adora's night stand.

Catra gave a little purr, hugging the pillow. She could still feel her heartbeat.

"Alright sleep, let's go." she said into the pillow which, while thin, was still substantial enough to mostly muffle her voice.

Time passed.

Catra held her head up and looked around the room.

Oh, come on.

Catra rolled onto her back and stared at the ceiling. It was the middle of the night and she hadn't slept at all. As she laid there she started running through all the preparations she needed to arrange. Food, music, flowers, guests….

"Arg! Lonnie!" Catra blurted out in a growl. She didn't care, of course, but it would have meant so much to Adora. Catra remembered the seemingly endless training exercises in the Fright Zone. Combat, agility drills, physical conditioning. So much running, so much lifting. A memory of Adora sneaking a glance at Lonnie in the locker room popped into Catra's head. She gritted her teeth.

Yeah, good riddance. I don't need competition on my wedding day.

The thought felt justified.

"Stupid buff Lonnie," Catra whispered.

Catra rolled onto her side and a tear rolled off her nose. She thought about trying to contact Adora on her tracker pad. If she were still close enough the signal could reach her.

No. She's probably asleep or busy.

Catra didn't want to worry Adora. This week was important and she wanted her Adora to be on the top of her game, not worrying about her.

Catra rolled onto her stomach on the middle of the bed, spreading her arms and legs wide, knocking off the covers and her jacket. She laid there until the rays of the day's first moon started creeping over the edge of the balcony and brightening the room.

Sleep hadn't come.

Catra got up and grumbled as she stripped down to shower and get ready for her day.

***

Adora looked down at the tracker pad that Bow had given her and saw no messages or calls had been received. Catra had made no attempt to contact her and she was worried. Adora didn't know if they were even still close enough to contact Etheria.

Catra had been a heavy sleeper ever since they were kids but lately Adora had caught Catra up at night. She would sometimes be sitting on the side of their bed or petting Melog. One night Adora saw her sitting on the edge of the balcony. The moonlight framed her in silhouette as her tail swayed with the slow pulse of the runestone. She was beautiful.

In that moment Adora had felt an insurmountable distance was between her and Catra. She wanted to cross that distance so desperately, to go to Catra, to sit with her. Hold her. Catra avoided talking about what happened to her and Adora knew Catra needed space. Time. It was something she hadn't had the best track record with. Not being overbearing, over protective. Catra had called her out on it what felt like ages ago.

Adora could hear Catra's voice.

"...it sure must be easy being a *people-pleaser* like you."

She was right. Adora had always tried to keep everyone happy, to protect everyone's feelings. To keep the peace. Back in the Fright Zone it was everything she could do to keep her team from each other's throats; though, it was mostly just Catra and Lonnie. Countless fights and bruises from breaking those two up and keeping them from beating each other senseless. Adora had been responsible for Catra. She was her duty. Adora had thought that if she could hold her team together tight enough, long enough, they could all be friends.

It had taken Adora a long time to learn to set boundaries. Time and friendship. Real friendship. Every day she was in the Fright Zone she wanted to build everyone together into a family. She hadn't even seen what a real family was until she had been taken from the Horde and brought to Bright Moon.

Adora remembered how Bow had reached out to her when they first met. If it weren't for him, Adora might not have joined the Rebellion. Bow had reached out with an invitation, not a demand or ultimatum. That one gesture grew in Adora but it still took her a long time, and a lot of work, to realize friendship wasn't only a function of her effort. She couldn't make people friends, she couldn't force them. She also couldn't take on other people's problems, their feelings, and carry them herself. That was an even harder lesson to learn.

Catra…

Adora wanted Catra to open up so badly; but, she knew pushing too hard would shut her down and risk them losing each other again.

"Adora."

Adora's leg was bouncing rapidly now and she was tapping at the screen of the tracker pad.

"Adora!" Glimmer's strained whisper cut into Adora's reminiscence.

"*Adora*, you're shaking the room!"

"I'm going to try to call Catra. Do you think I should call Catra?" Adora hurriedly whispered back.

"You can call later, just stop!" Glimmer put a hand on Adora's leg and hand on the communicator.

Adora pulled back the pad with a slight jerk. "I mean, maybe I'll just step out for a quick second and…"

Glimmer cut her off. “Adora!”

Their voices had risen above whispers, harsh and strained, too excited to be contained.

“EHEM!” Bow loudly cleared his throat.

Adora and Glimmer shared a glance and then looked up at Bow. He was standing at the head of a conference table in front of a holographic monitor that was displaying various aspects of Etherian culture. The eyes of the planet’s dignitaries, seated around the room, were all fixed on Glimmer and Adora. Bow’s face was scrunched into a frown and Adora could visibly see the outline of a vein throbbing on his forehead.

“Adora. *Queen* Glimmer.” When Bow said ‘queen’ he added a slight acidic emphasis. Glimmer’s breath escaped her in a little squeak.

“Do you two have anything you would care to share with the class or are we done?” Bow was staring directly at Glimmer. She seemed to shrink in her chair and replied with a meek, “Sorry.”

Bow’s stare snapped to Adora.

“And you, Adora?”

“Umm… uh, yeah, no. I’m good.” Adora tried to feign confidence but between Bow’s expression and her worry it came out in stilted spurts.

“As I was saying…” Bow continued his speech to the assembled leaders and Adora did her best to restrain herself. She glanced down at the tracker pad then back up at Bow. This was going to be a long day.

Catra stepped out of the shower, toweled off and dressed. The warmth of the shower had helped loosen some of the tension she

was holding but she still felt a tugging in her chest. Catra gave a little sigh as she pulled her hair back and secured her ponytail.

Catra stretched as she walked through the halls of Bright Moon castle. Breakfast was going to be necessary, she hadn't really eaten much the day before. She hoped she could get through some of the invitations while she ate. She stopped in front of Glimmer's office and reached toward the door.

No...

Catra withdrew her hand and took a small step back. Her ears pressed down to the sides of her head.

"Screw this, I'm going for a run." Out loud her tone was angry.

Turning heel, Catra walked down the hall to the great hall, arms tight by her sides. Her pace was rapid and determined.

Catra found the great hall of the castle mostly empty but for a few guards, out of uniform, chatting over breakfast before their shift. With the Queen gone there were no formal meals being held so people would come and go as they pleased and the food was generally kept to a lighter portable affair. Catra preferred this. Freedom.

As she passed by the guards came to attention.

"Good morning, Catra," they said in unison.

"Yeah, whatever." Catra's tone was dismissive, her gaze undissuaded from the kitchen entrance.

Catra strode into the kitchen. The room was heavy with the smell of baked goods and the aroma of fresh fruits caught Catra's nose. As she passed through she scooped up an arm's length of jelly tarts and popped one in her mouth.

The cook looked up, "Oh, good morning, Catra."

“Yup. Sure is.” Catra’s voice was muffled by the jelly tart but the sarcasm was obvious.

The cook looked down at the vegetables he was cutting and continued. “Well, I didn’t expect you’d be up this early so your breakfast isn’t ready yet.”

Catra hadn’t stopped walking. She was half way to the other side of the great hall before the cook realized. With a little shrug he went back to work.

***

Catra licked the last crumbs of a jelly tart from her fingers as she walked out the front gate of the castle. The tarts felt like they had settled into a lump in her stomach even though Catra usually relished the tarts. She had a habit of stashing some in her room when Adora wasn’t looking. It was a habit from the Fright Zone, one that Adora had never learned because she was too straight laced to indulge in contraband. Now Catra was the master of hiding delicious food places no one, especially Adora, could find it.

The guards nodded as she passed through Bright Moon’s gates but Catra had hardly noticed them. Her destination was the Whispering Woods. Since the return of magic she and Adora would often take long walks exploring the changes and new growth brought on by the influx of magical energy. Catra only came here alone when she needed some exercise time by herself.

When Adora had activated the fail-safe and deactivated The Heart of Etheria at the peak of it’s power it was as if a dam was dropped in the path of a rapidly rushing river. The magic hadn’t just returned, the flow out of Etheria being stopped so suddenly caused it to rebound and push back on the restraints the First Ones had used to contain it. The restraints meant to direct the plant’s magic to The Heart cracked and oozed magic, soaking

parts of Etheria in magic and resulting in some strange side effects.

Catra knew exactly where she wanted to be today. She started to jog lightly down the familiar path she had found with Adora only a month earlier. As she did she made sure to cut back the encroaching growth from the forest with her claws. Adora was more than content to let the forest reclaim old paths and form new ones for them to find together, but this place was Catra's and she wanted to be able to find it without the need of help from something, or someone, who flies.

Catra had arrived and stood at the base of an enormous tree. This tree was one of the many side effects of the return of magic. It had drunk deeply of the magic permeating the woods and grown twice as tall as any other. This was quite the sight to see considering the Whispering Wood already had some of the largest trees on Etheria. It was also an excellent work out to climb to the highest branches, a feat Catra had accomplished many times.

Catra's muscles took to climbing the tree like an old familiar friend and once at the top she breathed deeply with a sense of renewed freedom. It reminded her of how she would find moments to be alone in the Fright Zone, climbing among the industrial landscape of pipes, conduit, and twisted metal. Just being above everything, having the top down view helped her put everything in perspective. She used to enjoy looking down on people from heights they couldn't reach but, now she just liked the time to be alone and free of responsibilities.

Catra was glad that Scorpia had taken up the reigns of her family's former kingdom. Scorpia was determined to reclaim the zone and had taken on that duty with her typical cheerful enthusiasm. As Catra stood in the upper branches looking out over the forest she pondered what it would be like visiting Scorpia's kingdom transformed into something that didn't remind her of the worst…

She thought of Adora and sighed, smiling.

And best parts of her childhood.

Catra stayed there, lazly gazing over the Wood and Bright Moon, until the day's moons were threatening to set. She climbed back down the tree and when she landed on the ground stretched tall and fully, even her tail. The way her muscles ached she knew she would get some sleep tonight.

As she wound her way back to the edge of the wood a small symbol caught her eye in the dimming light. Any other eyes might have missed it, ones less able to see in dimming moonlight, others less familiar to the form. Catra caught it. It was carved in the bark of a tree. The symbol of the Horde but twisted, half of it turned up side down so it looked as if two winged beasts were consuming each other by their tails. This was the symbol adopted by a group of clones that had rejected individuality. This was the symbol of the cult of Prime Eternal.

Catra hissed and her fur stood on end. She had heard of them from Scorpia and her kingdom had the most reported activity from the cult. From Scorpia's accounts they were mostly a nuisance, randomly showing up at settlements and marching through, loudly proclaiming Prime's love and claiming to herald his return. Scorpia called them harmless. Catra had a different word.

Idiots.

Catra slashed down on the symbol with her claws, leaving deep gashes. Her own message that encroaching on Bright Moon was not welcome. Catra turned and continued on her way, her hand stroking her pony tail as she walked.

Idiots.

Sleep couldn't come soon enough.

***

Catra stretched as she walked through the halls of Bright Moon castle. The previous night's sleep was desperately need and exercise had been just the thing to get her there. Now all she needed was some breakfast.

As she walked through the corridors she passed the throne room and looked back. The guards weren't there. Even when the Queen was absent a minimum of two guards would stand watch.

Huh, must be a shift change?

Catra shrugged and turned to continue to the kitchen. Before she took another step her ears caught the twinkling pop of Glimmer's teleport come from the throne room.

Catra leaned into the doorway to see what was going on. The throne room was lit brightly by the morning moon, the colors washed out except where the shadow of a lone figure cut the light. Glimmer was standing, facing the throne with her back to the doorway.

Catra slipped through the door and walked across the throne room floor with a playful sway in her step.

"Hey Sparkles, you're back early. Just couldn't stay away, huh?" Catra's words didn't get a response. She stopped half way to the throne, Glimmer, still, standing several paces ahead of her. Catra felt the hairs on her neck begin to rise.

"Hey, GLIMMER. What's up?!" Catra's voice rose and she almost yelled.

Glimmer slowly turned her body and her head to look over her shoulder and regarded Catra. Catra felt her blood turn to ice water as she met Glimmer's gaze. Her eyes, solid green, stared back at Catra with sublime disregard.

"Hello. Catra." Glimmers voice was flat in tone.

Catra immediately took a defensive pose, coiled back, ears flat.

“What is going on, where’s Adora.” Catra spat the words at Glimmer.

Glimmer turned so her whole body faced Catra. “Adora? Don’t worry about her. This is our time. I came here for you, don’t you understand? Adora would only ruin it.” Her voice had no inflection, but her face showed unnerving concern at the idea that whatever she had planned would be ruined.

“What is this, what do you mean? Glimmer?!”

“Don’t worry. I think you’ll come to understand.” Glimmer gestured and a black tendril of energy lashed out at Catra. She sprang sideways, avoiding Glimmer’s attack and scrambled to the edge of the room. Catra pressed up against the wall, the room was devoid of cover but cutting off a direction of attack would help her predict where the next would come from. Darkness started to float off of Glimmer like a mist.

“Oh, you’re right Catra, how rude of me. A little game of cat and mouse before the main course would be much. More. Appropriate.” As Glimmer finished her sentence she teleported next to Catra. Catra’s reflexes did not fail her and she instinctively tucked and rolled out of the way, narrowly avoiding Glimmer’s umbra cloaked fist. The wall spalled and cracked where Glimmer struck it.

Catra felt bits of the wall bounce off her body as she scrambled on all fours toward the doorway to the throne room. As she moved she regained her footing and broke into a sprint. She needed to get out of the room, get some place Glimmer couldn’t find her. Catra knew she couldn’t take Glimmer one on one. Over the years of fighting the Rebellion, Catra had seen Glimmer turn from a weak spoiled brat to a serious force on the battlefield. With Horde Prime stripping away her inhibitions, Catra hoped she wouldn’t have to face Glimmer's full capability.

At the doorway Catra ran head long into an inky black field of energy. She bounce off and fell backwards, sliding back into the room.

“Were you always such a coward, Catra?” Glimmer jabbed, slowly floating on a mist of dark energy toward her pray.

Catra kicked herself back and rolled onto her feet, turning to face Glimmer.

“I’m not going to fight you, Sparkles.” Catra tried to sound determined.

“Okay.” Glimmer’s laconic response was punctuated by a flick of her wrist. Another tendril of darkness lashed out at Catra, this time catching her by the ankle and dragging her off her feet. Contact with the tendril felt like the warmth was being pulled from her. Her body began painfully shivering as she fell backward, her head hitting the floor.

Adora. Catra thought. *Please, somebody. I need to stall her, someone please come…*

Catra rolled onto her stomach and tried to get her feet under her. Her head was swimming with pain and her legs barely responded. She pushed herself up but fell forward onto her knees.

“Glimmer, please, we’re friends….”

“Oh!” Glimmer’s voice broke monotone and took on a sickening inflection. “You’re going to try to appeal to our friendship? Try to find something deep inside me to get me to stay my hand?” Glimmer softly landed and walked toward Catra. Each foot step crackled with energy. Glimmer smiled, swaying while she walked, playful. She was enjoying this. “Don’t you get it? I hate you. I always have.”

Catra heard her own words, her expression of love for Adora, turned back on her and felt the world begin to shrink and constrict around her.

How did Prime know?

Her vision began to turn pale and she couldn't hold back her tears. Feeling drained from her body, arms and legs limp and weak, Catra wait for Glimmer's next move.

Glimmer stopped in front of Catra. "Pathetic."

"I'm…. sorry." Catra sobbed. "I…"

"You're what?" Glimmer's voice took on a tone of sharp anger. She tilted an ear toward Catra.

"I'm sorry for every thing I did to you, Glimmer." Catra's voice came out wheezing, her throat barely letting the words squeeze out.

"An apology? You want my forgiveness?" Glimmer's voice was sadistic, her eyes dripping black from the edges around the green. "I will not forgive you, Catra."

Glimmer knelt in front of Catra, taking her chin with the tips of her fingers and holding her face up eye to eye.

"I should thank you, Catra. You set me free. I was nothing, a weakling, pathetic." Glimmer's face suddenly lost all emotion. "Thank you, Catra, for setting me free. Thank you, for killing my mother."

Something snapped inside Catra. This was a break that had happened many times over Catra's life. She had learned to keep it in check, but this instinct was from deep in her childhood. Whenever she was bullied, whenever someone made her feel powerless. Catra felt an electric shock innervate her arm and like so many times before her feelings of inadequacy and powerlessness turned to rage.

Catra slashed her claws across Glimmer's throat.

Glimmer shot to her feet and staggered back. Her hands were clutching her throat tightly but blood was beginning to seep through her fingers. Her eyes flickered and the green light and aura of darkness dissipated. Glimmer looked down at Catra with a dumbfounded, pleading look. She fell to her knees, eyes rolling back in her head, and as she fell forward reached a hand out to Catra.

Catra couldn't breath.

"Glimmer." she said weakly. "No."

Catra reached a hand out to touch Glimmer's but withdrew it ahead of a spreading pool of blood.

"No…"

Catra stood up and began backing to the doorway. Her tears had stopped. She couldn't take her eyes off Glimmer.

"No…."

Something solid stopped Catra from backing out of the room. She turned slightly, looking over her shoulder to see She-Ra, eyes glowing green.

"Catra." Adora's voice was stern. "I didn't know you were such an animal."

***

Catra pulled her self awake, screaming. As she sat up her claws slid effortlessly through the bed clothes and mattress.

Deep sobs wracked her body and she let out another scream. The door to her room burst open and two castle guards entered.

"GET OUT!" Catra screamed as she threw a pillow at them, trailing tattered shreds of cloth. The guards looked at each other and backed out of the room.

Catra pulled her knees under her and she leaned forward, resting her face on her mattress to muffle her sobs and cries of pain.

I need to talk to her…

What was Adora going to think?

She'll never let me out of her sight again…

Catra's thoughts quickly turned over in her mind, racing. Adora and Bow's disappointment, Glimmer's silent judgment.

Catra grabbed her biceps and began squeezing her hands as if to hug herself. Her claws dug into her flesh and the pain shocked her. Panicked into a moment of clarity she scrambled to the writing desk and grabbed her tracker pad. She fell on her knees on the floor, turned on the communicator and selected Adora's channel. Her finger hovered above the call button.

What is she going to think… I can't…

Catra looked down at the communicator, tears falling from her eyes onto it's surface. She slumped down, defeated. Her arms stung.

I need to…

Catra scrolled further on the communicator and pushed the call button.

"Please pick up… please." Catra's voice was shaken by her rapid breathing.

“Hi, Catra!” Scorpia answered with her usual bubbly enthusiasm. “Are you okay, are you crying?!” Her enthusiasm turned to concern.

“Scorpia, please. I need someone to talk to. I don’t feel safe.”

Scorpia’s face became serious, her voice filled with determination. “I’m on my way!”

“Scorpia, NO! Don’t hang up!” Catra’s protests fell to silence as Scorpia’s channel cut out. “Scorpia… the Fright Zone is hours away…” Catra’s crying had evolved to a strained wheezing and her voice was becoming ragged.

She dropped the communicator pad and let out a quivering sigh of disappointment.

Then Catra heard something unexpected. She heard the flap of feathered wing across the courtyard. Coming closer. Closer.

“ALLONS Y!”

Swiftwind's voice was unmistakable. No sooner had Catra processed this than the form of Scorpia landed on her balcony, tucked unto a forward roll and scooped her up in one movement.

“SCORPIA!?” Catra was a mixture of surprised and relieved.

“Oh! Catra!” Scorpia squeezed Catra tightly in a hug. “What is going on!?”

Scorpia looked around the room. The bed was in several pieces and both night stands were knocked over, splinters of wood scattered across the floor.

“Scorpia… how are you here?!” Catra’s head throbbed and processing what was happening didn’t help.

“Oh! I was at Swiftwind’s because Adora said,” Scorpia put on her best serious Adora impression. “‘Scorpia, I am worried about

Catra, could you stay close and keep an eye on her?'"

A swirl of emotions rocked Catra at once. Quickly one coalesced and forced it's way to the surface. "She… didn't trust me?!" Catra began sobbing again.

"Oh, oh, jeez." Scorpia stroked Catra's hair. "No, Catra, she was just worried, she loves you."

Catra calmed down slighly and her eyes focused. She saw the damaged she had caused to the room.

"NO!" Catra shocked Scorpia as she suddenly sprang from her arms. "Where is it!?"

Catra began frantically searching through the damaged furniture and scraps of cloth and mattress stuffing. Scorpia knelt beside her.

"What are we looking for? Tell me and I'll help you find it."

"Adora's hair tie… she gave it to me."

"Okay." Scorpia helped Catra by cleaning up the debris while she searched. Fewer hiding spots would make it easier to find.

"Got it!" Catra found the hair tie under a piece of broken night stand. She wrapped it around two fingers on her right hand.

"Better?" Scorpia put a claw on Catra's shoulder and gave a gentle squeeze.

"Yeah." Catra leaned against Scorpia. "Could you stay here tonight?" Her voice was still wavering with a dry rasp, but her crying had stopped.

Scorpia scooped Catra back up and cradled her in her lap. "You got it!" Some how Scorpia's enthusiasm calmed Catra.

"Scorpia…"

"Yeah?"

"I… have you had any trouble sleeping since…"

Scorpia looked down at Catra. She was curled up and breathing slowly.

"Oh yeah, I had a lot of trouble sleeping." Scorpia's tone was very matter-of-fact. "For the longest time I kept having nightmares about what happened. It. Was. Horrible!"

Catra looked up at Scorpia and saw her smiling down at her. Scorpia was always so naive and pure, the thought of her being troubled by anything seemed wrong to Catra.

"I…" Catra's voice wavered. "I keep remembering things… not just about… him. Everything is so different now, my life has changed so much that everything I remember from before… from the Horde… it all seems so wrong, like they aren't even my memories. And, I can't always control them, keep them out."

"Does Adora know? I mean, she was worried, but does she know whats going on?"

Scorpia's question struck Catra a little. Catra didn't want to be a burden and was afraid to talk to Adora. She didn't want Adora to see her as weak and make herself Adora's responsibility again.

Catra's instinct was to become defensive, to snap back at Scorpia with sarcasm.

"I… don't know how to tell her," was all she could manage.

"Hey! You know who helps me think through things? Perfuma! My wildflower's always got all these neat tricks that help me really focus, ya know?"

Perfuma had offered to help Catra before. Even in that offer she had helped Catra more than she knew. To start opening up, to accept being vulnerable. Catra had needed every kick in the right direction to get her to let herself support Adora without fear of rejection, to just love her. To take a chance and believe it could be

worth it. That she was worth something. Catra nodded slightly, dozing off.

Sorpia could feel Catra's breathing slow. The hairs on her claws had been picking up every beat of Catra's heart, slowing, softening. Catra was exhausted and had fallen asleep in her arms. Scorpia rested her head on top of Catra's, cradling her until morning.

***

When Catra woke she had thanked Scorpia for staying with her and hurried to the hangar. Now that there was peace on Etheria, The Fright Zone and Bright Moon had begun engaging in some limited trade. One of the first acquisitions on the part of Bright Moon was a small number of air skiffs to make travel easier and faster between the kingdoms.

Catra hopped on one of the skiffs. It was a model similar to the one she and Adora had crashed in the Whispering Wood what seemed like ages ago. A lot had changed since then and a Horde skiff painted in the colors and livery of Bright Moon was one of them.

Catra was certain no one would question her taking a skiff out for a spin. Being engaged to one of the princesses opened doors. It was boring some times, having things just handed to you. Catra had fought for everything she earned in the Horde. She had made a name for herself but it was a hard lesson to learn that she had not earned any loyalty or respect from her subordinates.

Slowly guiding the skiff out of the hangar, Catra pushed the remembrance to the back of her mind. Plumeria was only a half day's travel away by air skiff. She needed to focus on the task at hand and lately dwelling on her past just seemed to keep her from moving. Before she left Scorpia had made Catra promise to

travel to Plumeria and talk to Perfuma. Catra didn't need to make that promise, she knew she needed help and was determined to find it. The events the previous night had shaken her and her eyes still stung from the tears, body still exhausted despite sleep.

The change in wilderness as she approached Plumeria was gradual but undeniable. The woods became somehow more wild with life, yet more managed. The air became sweeter, fragrant with fruit tree blossoms and fertile soil. Plumeria had been the bread basket of the Seven Kingdoms for generations before the war with the Horde, rivaled only by Salineas in trade for staple foods. Rivaled until Salineas was sacked by the Horde and put to the torch. Catra gritted her teeth and growled in frustration.

Stop thinking, Catra.

Catra slowed slowed the skiff and came to rest at the edge of a settlement. Catra had been to Plumeria once before and knew very little of the landscape. Once with Adora, Glimmer and Bow on a mission to discuss relief efforts and allocation of resources between the Fright Zone and Salineas. Catra tried her best to stay out of the negotiation, to keep her distance. If she could have she would have slipped invisibly off with Melog and just avoided it all together but her presence was important to Adora.

Catra hopped off the skiff. Villagers we already starting to drop their tasks and assembled to greet her. She remembered how friendly the people of Plumeria were the last time she was here. Showering the entourage with flower petals, dancing around them and playing music for them. That level of friendliness put Catra on edge. In Catra's life, people being nice to you usually meant they wanted something or were looking for you to drop your guard long enough to stab you in the back. Being constantly on guard here felt unnecessary, but she still couldn't shake the habit.

The villagers began to form a semi-circle in front of Catra, a mixture of adults and children, waving and offering greetings. Catra meekly waved back.

“I’m here for Perfuma, where is she.” Catra blurted out.

The small assembly began looking at each other nervously. Catra inhaled sharply.

“Ah. I’m *looking* for Perfuma and was wondering if you could *help* me find her.” Catra’s wording was now deliberate. She’d been too used to giving orders and rephrasing was something she was working on. “Please.” She was also working on gratitude.

The group looked almost as if they gave a sigh of relief in unison. They beckoned Catra to follow them and as she walked with them they formed a circle around her. The children were skipping and frolicking, the adults laughing and making small talk. This place couldn’t have felt more alien to Catra if she were on another planet. The group lead her through the village and as they approached the edge one member of the group indicated a path leading to a copse of trees. Perfuma would be there.

Catra thanked them for the help and turned to step onto the path. As she did a child, thin with little horn bumps on their head, broke from the group and ran up to her. Stretching, the child put a large orange flower in Catra’s hair. Catra reflexively grabbed the child’s arm, yanking them off the ground. The flower fell and a horrified expression burst out on the child’s face. Catra caught herself too late and dropped the child who landed in their feet and ran back to the on looking group, now huddled closer together, whispering to each other with expressions of serious concern.

“I… I’m sorry.” Catra quickly stammered out as she backed away onto the path. She turned and walked hurriedly away, pressing the heels of her palms against her eyes. She could feel panic and anger leaving her body as she walked. Her reaction felt like instinct, like a part of her. She hated it.

“Way to make a good impression, Catra.”

A short walk into the trees revealed that they formed a ring around a sheltered garden. Perfuma, clad in her usual long pink

gown adorned with flowers and small vines was smiling and humming to herself as she moved about tending the plants. As soon as Catra stepped into the garden Perfuma looked up at her.

“Oh! You’re just in time, Catra!” Perfuma’s voice was bubbly and excited.

“Um…” Catra shot a look of disbelief, “You were expecting me?”

“Oh, no, I just like saying that because it sounds so much more special, but; come here! I do need your help.” Perfuma waved Catra over to the edge of the garden. Catra hesitantly approached, holding her arm close to her body with the opposite hand. As she drew nearer she saw that the garden was filled with what appeared to be flattened plants. The stalks were bent and twisted, laying over each other in a thick mat making it difficult to discern one plant from another.

“Do we need to… pull this stuff out or something? I’m not really much of a gardener.” Catra’s voice was low and apprehensive.

Perfuma looked at her with a broad smile. “No, silly! Yesterday these plants were growing tall and strong. Last night there was a storm and with the wind and the rain the plants bent over. See!” Perfuma knelt down and lifted one of the plants a little. “They have stems that can bend if the wind is too strong to keep the leaves from being damaged. In a few days they’ll all be back to normal and in a week they’ll be flowering. It’ll be so beautiful!”

“So what do you need me to do?” Catra asked, her tone was slightly incredulous.

“While the plants are like this, they’re vulnerable. Other things can move in and take up space they need to grow or animals could come through and trample them. We need to take care only to remove the things that will cause problems for now. Once the plants have re-established themselves they’ll be able to out grow most things, but I’ll still have to come through and make sure nothing really destructive has taken root.” Perfuma unwrapped a

small vine from the stalk of one of the flower plants. “It’s a shame, before this was a garden these could have grown wild here, but now there’s so much more that we want for this space.”

Catra knelt down and started poking around the plants, occasionally pulling out a clump of grass or a vine threatening to choke one of the plants Perfuma aimed to protect.

“I’ve never gardened before. The Fright Zone didn’t really have plants while I was growing up.” Catra’s voice had a slight tinge of sorrow of missing out. She’d come to appreciate spending time in nature on her walks with Adora and she much preferred it over the ubiquitous, unnatural softness of Bright Moon or the sharp, ridgid industry of the Fright Zone.

Perfuma nodded. “Oh! I never asked why I had your company today!”

“I… I need your help. Before you said you could help me with… meditation? Scorpia seems convinced you can work miracles.” Catra’s tone was low, getting the words out was difficult. She hated feeling helpless, but she knew she needed something to be different and had to get out of her own head or she would drown in the misery she was constantly inflicting on herself. “I keep… having nightmares and remembering things from before.” Her voice trailed off and she looked down at the ground.

“Oh! Catra.” Perfuma’s voice was sweetly concerned. “You should be proud of yourself that you came here. Feeling a need to grow beyond one's past self and into something new is frightening sometimes. Let’s finish here and I can show you some techniques that should help you.”

Perfuma and Catra spent the rest of the afternoon tending to the garden. Once the first moon came low on the horizon they went to Perfuma’s yurt and ate a dinner of nuts, fruits and vegetables. The yurt itself was made of a natural cloth dyed pink. The floor was covered in elaborately woven mats and furnished with hand

made cushions. Clay pieces similar to what Adora had called 'wind chimes' were hung from the poles holding everything up.

“Now, let’s begin.” Perfuma gestured to a low, round cushion. “Have a seat here.”

Catra sat on the cushion and pulled her knees up to her chest. She barely fit on the cushion.

“Catra, I want you to close your eyes and take a deep, cleansing breath.” Perfuma sat cross legged and brought her arms above her head into a circle as she took a deep breath, lowering them into her lap as she slowly exhaled.

Catra closed her eyes and followed Perfuma's lead, taking a deep breath, exhaling slowly.

“Now, I want you to bring someone to mind that you find easy to love and reach out to them with feelings of love and kindness.” Perfuma exhaled slowly while she spoke giving her voice a light airiness.

“Okay.” Even closed, Catra’s eyes rolled. She settled her body and stuck out her hand, arm straight in front of her as if trying to grasp at a distant object. Catra murmured out loud, “Adora.”

Perfuma reached out and took Catra’s out stretched hand. “I said someone you find easy to love, not the person you love the most.”

Catra opened her eyes and looked at Perfuma. She was shocked a little that Perfuma would suggest that Adora wasn’t easy to love. Catra had grown to love Adora over the course of their childhood together. Adora was always there, always reached out to Catra when she needed comfort, always subbornly pulled Catra out of her spirals of self loathing and anger. Then a pang of memory struck her, the day Adora had left the hoard, left her. She saw Adora’s determination to make the world right, to stubbornly defend a new innocent thing in danger. Catra was jealous. Adora’s determination and support was HER'S. And then Adora said it.

“We can fix this…”

Catra’s remembered her reaction, how she screamed in her mind and wanted to scream out loud, “I don’t need to be fixed! I need you to stay with me!”

Adora’s words had under cut everything Catra had accomplished, had struggled for. She was finally being seen as worthy of command and Adora had told her that her world was broken.

Catra caught herself and inhaled sharply. Perfuma was looking at her with a little smile, still holding her hand. Catra pulled back her hand, her ears flattened and she looked down and away.

“Yeah. I guess my relationship with Adora is complicated.” Catra took a deep breath and closed her eyes again. As she slowly exhaled she whispered, “Scorpia.”

Perfuma giggled a little. “I think so too.” Catra could hear an uncharacteristic twinkle of pride in Perfuma’s voice.

Catra and Perfuma sat in silence for what felt like hours. It was hard for Catra to keep thoughts from pushing themselves in to the edges of her attention. Thoughts of how she had treated Scorpia, abused their relationship crept in around the edges of her attention. Catra remembered how Scorpia had almost instantaneously accepted Catra’s appology, had accepted that Catra had changed. This filled Catra with resolve, determination to keep that change growing, moving forward.

A little bell chimed. Catra opened her eyes. She felt weird. Emotionally drained but not numb. If fuzzy were a feeling, that was how Catra felt.

“It’s late and we should probably get to sleep, you have a long trip a head of you tomorrow.” Perfuma put her hand on Catra’s shoulder and gave it a little squeeze. “It’s going to take a while, if you want to visit from time to time we can move on to harder things. Learning to express love and kindness for people who’ve

hurt you. People you've hurt. It might help… uncomplicate things?"

Catra smiled. "Yeah, I think I'd like that."

"Oooo! We can even work on some lucid dreaming techniques to help with your nightmares!" Perfuma bursted with excitement.

Catra laughed, "Yeah, I think I *need* that, too."

Perfuma extinguished the lanterns and Catra buried herself under a pile of cushions. Catra felt hopeful that she could keep moving her life forward, she had a future with Adora and wanted to be present in that future. As Catra thought of her future she slowly drifted off to sleep.

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Catra stretched as she walked out of Perfuma's yurt and made her way back to the air-skiff. As she walked through the village the people all came up and gave her little parting gifts, a basket of apples, a basket of flowers, and a basket of wind chimes. Catra laughed as she approached the skiff. Maybe the quaintness of the place was growing on her.

Catra saw the head of the child from yesterday poke up from over the edge of the skiff as she approached. Startled she dropped the baskets she was carrying, apples and wind chimes clattering to the ground. The child gave a start and hopped off the skiff and ran back to the village.

"I'm sor…" Catra cut herself off, the child was well out of ear shot before she could finish her apology. She put the apples and wind chimes back in their respective baskets and loaded everything onto the skiff. Catra jumped up onto the deck of the skiff and noticed a small doll laying where the child was. It was a hand

made cloth doll, a little cat person with a short pony tail and an orange flower in it's hair. Catra picked up the doll and pressed it gently to her face. She put the doll on one of the crew seats and buckled it in.

“Alright, little me. Ready for an adventure? Let’s go home.” Catra took her place at the control rudder of the skiff and lifted off, heading back to Bright Moon.

The noon moons were bright in the sky by the time Catra arrived at the skiff's hangar. As she came around to land she saw that Darla was on the landing pad. A small knot of concern hit the pit of her stomach. The mission for the Best Friends Squad wasn’t supposed to have returned for a few more days.

Catra landed the skiff, unbuckled her doll and grabbed the cargo she had stowed. The ground crew had already surrounded the skiff doing maintenance checks. Catra could see a look of relief on some of their faces as if they were worried they would never have seen the skiff again.

Catra made her way back up to Castle Bright Moon and through the halls to her and Adora’s room. She pushed open the door and saw Adora sitting on the torn up bed. Adora was leaning forward, elbows on her knees and her face in her palms.

“Hey, Adora.” Catra’s words came out timidly. Seeing Adora amid the damage she’d caused, she couldn’t begin to imagine what Adora was thinking and she felt a lush of embarrassment.

Adora looked up, her eyes were red with tears.

“CATRA!” She jumped off the bed and pulled Catra into a tight hug. The baskets she carried fell to the floor, their contents spilling out.

“WEWERESOWORRIEDWHATHAPPENEDAREYOUOKAYMELOGFREAKEDOUTANDWECAMEBACKASQUICKLYASWECOULD,” Adora was loudly stammering out a string of nearly incomprehensible words only punctuated by sobs and sniffles.

Catra put her arms around Adora and buried her face into her shoulder. “I’m here, I didn’t leave.” Adora seemed to calm down a little bit and began again.

“Melog freaked out while we were sleeping and broke into Glimmer’s room. She pushed Glimmer into a corner and wouldn’t let anyone near her for an hour. It was like she was trying to protect Glimmer from something.”

Melog phased back to being visible in the room and curled around their legs, mewling softly to Catra as she rubbed her head against Catra’s side.

“I know, I’m sorry, I didn’t really expect it either,” Catra patted Melog on the head.

“What happened, Catra. I was so scared when I got back and you weren’t here and the room was. Was like this.” Adora looked back at the bed, loosening her hug a little.

“Adora, let’s get this cleaned up.” Catra told Adora about the events of the past two days as they went about cleaning up the damage. Adora winced as Catra related the details of her nightmare.

“Well, I think I know why Melog freaked out. We were pretty far away and you two were still so strongly connected.” Adora’s look betrayed surprise but Melog gave a series of meows that seemed to challenge the incredulity.

“Yeah, she is sometimes,” Catra said to Melog as she scratched between her ears.

Adora furrowed her brow, “Hey! No fair!”

“Hey, Adora,” Catra looked down at her hands. “Could you let everyone know I’m okay. I just… I just want to stay in tonight. I have a lot to think about.”

Adora nodded. “Okay.” She looked around room, it was mostly empty now, the broken furniture and bedding were now bundled up. Adora heaved the bundle onto her shoulders, staggering a little and pulled it through the door, out of the room. “I will be right back.” She called back from the hallway.

Melog mewled at Catra. “Yeah, it’s one of the things I love about her.” Melog nuzzled Catra’s hand at her reply, purring softly.

Catra took Adora’s absence as an opportunity to take a quick shower. The dust from the trip to and from Plumeria in the open air skiff clung to her fur and the warmth of the shower was relaxing. After toweling off Catra grabbed some comfortable clothes, a pair of loose shorts and a pull over shirt, dressed and walked out to the balcony. Catra sat up on the railing and leaned against the wall her tail slowly swinging off the side of the balcony. Melog rubbed up against her leg and Catra petted her between the ears.

Eventually Adora pushed open the door and dragged in a new mattress bundled in fresh bedding.

“Hey Catra, I got a new…” Adora’s voice was huffing with the physical exertion. She looked over at Catra sitting on the edge of the balcony and what was left of her breath was taken from her.

“… mattress.”

Catra waved for Adora to come over. Adora dropped the bundle of bedding and walked out on to the balcony. The edge of the balcony was wide, tightly set stone, but Adora didn’t trust herself to sit on it as Catra did so she slid down against it in front of Catra.

Catra moved her hand to rub the top of Adora’s head but Adora took it and put it against the side of her face. Adora sighed into Catra’s hand.

“Why didn’t you tell me what was going on.” Adora’s voice was quiet, hesitant. She felt she was on the precipice of prying too

much but she needed to know.

Catra looked down at Bright Moon Castle's courtyard. "I don't know. I was scared. I thought if I told you what was going on that you'd have me locked up in here so I would never be in danger again."

Adora looked up at Catra. "I was so worried, when I would wake up and you weren't sleeping. It had gone on so long."

"Why didn't you tell me you were worried?"

"I… I just thought you needed space. When you were ready you'd open up. When you were still in the Horde, I always thought there was something I could do or say that could bring you back, make you see what could be different. Every time I did it pushed you away and I thought… I just… I can't lose you again," tears were starting to roll down Adora's cheeks and her voice was shaking. Melog laid across Adora's lap and licked her chin in sympathy.

"Adora… I. You know what really kept me from telling you?" Catra's words sounded stern and Adora's jaw visibly clenched in anticipation. "I didn't want you to think I was broken. I didn't want you to feel like I was something you needed to save. I don't want you to have to be responsible for me again. It makes me feel powerless, weak. Like I don't deserve you. Those feelings pushed me to do some horrible things. I don't want to be that Catra anymore."

Catra looked down at Adora. They were both crying now, sniffling.

"Look at us. We really need to do this more often, but maybe after less panic?" Adora laughed a little as she spoke.

"Yeah. That sound good because if I have anything to say about it, we're going to be each other's problem for a long time." Catra gave a little laugh, "Hey, look, the last moon's going down."

"Oh, I should get ready for bed!" Adora stood and turned to walk back inside but Catra caught her hand.

“Just stay and watch moonset with me.” Catra pulled Adora close to her and they watched as the last moon of the day slipped beneath the horizon and it’s bright light was replaced with the dim silver light of three of it’s smaller sisters rising on the opposite horizon. As their eyes adjusted to the change in light the stars became visible, still a spectacle to see even though they had both been among them many times.

“I’m going to go get ready,” Adora said, giving Catra a quick kiss on the cheek before parting.

Catra hopped off the edge of the balcony and stepped into the room to unpack the bundle of bedding. She rolled out the mattress and neatly laid the blankets on top of it. Catra pulled the hair tie from her pony tail and shook out her hair. As she looked around she grimaced that her usual spot to put it had been destroyed. Then an idea struck her. She picked up the little doll and wrapped the hair tie around it’s arm.

“Here, keep this safe for me.” Catra said to the doll with a little smirk. She then placed the doll next to her side of the bed and slipped under the covers, waiting for Adora. Melog had curled up at the foot of the bed and was purring gently.

Adora came back into the room dressed in a long, loose-fitting tunic and shorts. She slipped into bed next to Catra and leaned in to kiss her.

Catra popped herself up on an elbow and put her finger to Adora’s lips.

“Um… one thing that I need to say, now that we’re working on better communication. Could you, please, if I am asleep, or look like I am asleep… please don’t try to cuddle me from behind. It really freaks me out and I don’t want that feeling to ever come between us.”

Adora was taken aback and blushed in embarrassment.

"I…" Adora began to apologize but cut herself off and just nodded in agreement.

Catra smiled and wrapped her arms around Adora, burying her face against Adora's chest. Adora put her arms around Catra and kissed her on the top of the head. The two of them fell asleep to Melog's contented purring.

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Glimmer, head down, hurried to the castle's great hall. After cutting their mission short there was no formal meeting this morning, the delegates wouldn't be returning until next week to plan the future meeting of the Princess Alliance. Meetings to set up meetings to plan and prepare for future meetings. The bureaucracy of it all was enough to make Glimmer's head spin. This morning's breakfast would at least just be a small informal group of friends.

Just one more corner, one more hall and Glimmer would be there. Her pace and heart rate quickened.

Why didn't I just leave with Bow.

Glimmer's thought was interrupted when she rounded the corner and ran headlong into Catra. Catra gave a little yelp and Glimmer fell backward, instinctively teleporting herself into an upright position.

"Glimmer, sorry…" Catra saw Glimmer's surprised expression, heard her rapid breathing. Normally a small surprise like this would subside quickly, but it persisted for Glimmer even as she straightened her outfit.

"Are you okay?" Catra continued.

Glimmer quickly shot back, “I’m fine, it’s nothing.”

“Yeah, I’ve been fine a lot too, lately.” Catra smirked at Glimmer’s attempt to hid her distress.

“No, I’m…”

“Fine.”

“Yeah,” Glimmer looked down at the ground. Her hand tensed into a fist and she snapped to look straight at Catra. “Catra. Please don’t use my office. Or enter my office when I’m not around, it was…”

“Your mom’s.” Catra cut her off.

“It… was.” Glimmer’s eyes began to shimmer with tears.

“When I realized, I knew I didn’t belong there… I’m sorry.” Catra’s ears flattened and she turned her eyes down and away from Glimmer’s gaze.

Glimmer was trying to control her breathing, slow and deliberate.

“Glimmer, I don’t want this to be the thing we have between us. I….” Catra stopped herself. She looked up at Glimmer. “Hey, can you ditch breakfast, I want to show you something.”

Glimmer was shocked. Since the defeat of Horde Prime, Catra had been almost a constant presence but never without Adora around. Catra would habitually be late for meetings and functions and Adora would usually try to cover for her. According to Adora this was how Catra was even in The Horde. Glimmer felt that Catra was trying to blend into the background, stay out of the limelight. She was also sure that Catra was going out of her way to avoid being alone with her. For Catra to not only be in the hall on time for breakfast; but, to also be reaching out to Glimmer, this had to be important.

“Yeah, where are we going?” Glimmer relaxed her hand and smiled a little.

“Meet me at the path into the Whispering Wood.” Catra rolled some numbers around in her head. “In fifteen… no, thirty minutes.” Glimmer nodded and Catra turned to run back to her room.

Glimmer teleported into the Great Hall behind Adora and Bow. Bow startled and dropped his muffin on the floor.

“Glimmer!”

Bow was barely able to say anything before Glimmer said rapidly, “I’m going to go hang out with Catra, I’ll see you later, byeeeeee!” She teleported off, leaving Adora and Bow looking at each other with puzzled expressions.

Glimmer popped out of her teleport at the entrance of the trail into the Whispering Wood from Bright Moon. She sat down on a log and waited.

It wasn’t long before Catra came running and when she reached Glimmer doubled over, panting.

“Did you sprint the whole way here?!” Glimmer was surprised.

“Yeah, I did.” Catra stood up, stretched, and ran her hands back over her hair. “You ready?”

“I guess?” Glimmer chuckled, she didn’t know what was going on but was happy to play along.

“Good, try to keep up.” Catra bolted off into the Whispering Woods.

“Try not to pass out!” Glimmer called after her before teleporting to Catra. Catra was running fast and the path seemed to wind randomly so Glimmer had to keep making short quick teleports to keep next to her. Eventually Catra came to a stop and leaned up

against a tall embankment. Glimmer teleported next to her and she held up a hand.

"Hold on, just let me catch my breath." Catra was panting and wheezing heavily. "All this easy living has really cut into my physical conditioning."

Glimmer laughed. "So, what brings us deep into the Whispering Woods?"

Catra pointed up. Glimmer looked up the embankment and realized it just kept going up into the sky. It wasn't an embankment at all, it was an enormous tree.

"That is one big tree." Glimmer thought if she tried to bend backward to behold all of it she would fall over.

"Just wait till we get to the top." Catra shot Glimmer a quick grin and began scaling the tree.

Glimmer teleported up along with Catra, from branch to branch. Catra knew every hand hold, every crevasse and cleavage that she could use to ascend and it it wasn't long before they were both in the upper branches.

Catra leaned up against the trunk of the tree. "Well, here it is." She gestured out broadly.

Glimmer looked around her and the depth of the situation suddenly sunk in. She could see the entirety of her kingdom, from the edge of the Whispering Wood to the rim of mountains surrounding Bright Moon Castle. She clasped her hands together and smiled broadly.

"Oh! I can even see the castle from here!" It was small, but the light from the moons caught it's white and silver spires and it seemed to twinkle like a star in the distance.

Glimmer was filled with awe and sat down on the edge of the branch, kicking her legs free in the open air.

She looked back at Catra, “Thank you, for showing this to me. I teleport every where so much I guess I miss out on seeing what's in between where I am and where I am going.”

Catra walked out onto the branch and sat next to Glimmer, her tail swaying behind her. “Just, don’t tell Adora, okay? As much as I love her, sometimes I just need to get away and think alone, you know?”

“I promise, this place is beautiful, though I guess it’s ours now?” Glimmer’s voice was bright and playful.

“Sure is, Sparkles.” Catra nudged Glimmer’s elbow. “Hey.” Catra’s tone suddenly became serious. “I never knew my mom and Shadow Weaver was… It’s just, I hear about how great Angella was and I was hoping you could tell me about her.”

Glimmer looked a Catra, she was looking down at her feet, ears low. She nudged Catra’s elbow with hers.

“Yeah? I would love to.”

THE END

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rev.2

End Notes

I screen shot milestones of hits and kudos, so don't worry about ruining any particular number.

Musical Cue for this story was https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-iIs9mK8VSg

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